

L.A. not waiting for state to set fire rules

City Council’s move to establish a more lenient ‘Zone Zero’ is stirring some concern.

By Noah Haggerty

As the state continues multiyear marathon discussions on rules for what residents in wildfire hazard zones must do to make the first five feet from their houses — an area dubbed “Zone Zero” — ember-resistant, the Los Angeles City Council voted Tuesday to start creating its own version of the regulations that is more lenient than most proposals currently favored in Sacramento.

Critics of Zone Zero, who are worried about the financial burden and labor required to comply as well as the detrimental impacts to urban ecosystems, have been particularly vocal in Los Angeles. However, wildfire safety advocates worry the measures endorsed by L.A.’s City Council will do little to prevent homes from burning.

“My motion is to get advice from local experts, from the Fire Department, to actually put something in place that makes sense, that’s rooted in science,” said City Councilmember John Lee, who put forth the motion. “Sacramento, unfortunately, doesn’t consult with the largest city in the state — the largest area that deals with wildfires — and so, this is our way of sending a message.”

Tony Andersen — executive officer of the state’s Board of Forestry and Fire Protection, which is in charge of creating the regulations — has repeatedly stressed the board’s commitment to incorporating L.A.’s feedback. Over the last year, the board hosted a contentious public meeting in Pasadena, walking tours with L.A. residents and numerous virtual workshops and hearings.

With the state long past its original Jan. 1, 2023, deadline to complete the regulations, several cities around the state have taken the matter into their own hands and adopted regulations ahead of the state, including Berkeley and San Diego.

“With the lack of guidance from the State Board of Forestry and Fire Protection, the City is left in a pre-

[See Buffer, A8]



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BACKING THE GOVERNMENT

Supporters of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei rally. Iran’s death toll reportedly has surpassed 2,000. **WORLD, A2**

Iran protests bring hope, dread

Southern California’s large diaspora is on edge and partly in the dark

By Hailey Branson-Potts

Tabby Refael’s messages to Iran are going unanswered.

For weeks, she has called, texted and sent voice memos to loved ones in Tehran, where massive crowds have demanded the overthrow of the country’s authoritarian government.

Are you OK? Refael — a West Los Angeles-based writer and Iranian refugee — has texted, over and over. Do you have enough food? Do you have enough water? Are you safe?

No response.

When the protests, initially spurred by economic woes, began in late December, Refael consistently got answers. But those stopped last week, when Iranian authorities imposed a near-total internet blackout, at the same time that calls to telephone landlines were also failing to connect. Videos circulating online show rows and rows of body bags.

And human rights groups say the government is waging a deadly crackdown on protesters in Tehran and other cities, with more than 2,000 killed.

Like many in Southern California’s large Iranian diaspora, Refael, 43, has been glued to her phone, constantly refreshing the news trickling out from Iran, where, she fears, there is “a wholesale massacre occurring in the literal dark.”

“Before the regime completely blacked out the internet, and in many places, electricity, there was an electrifying sense of hope,” said Refael, a prominent voice in Los Angeles’ Persian Jewish community. But now, as the death toll rises, “that hope has been devastatingly tempered with a sense of visceral dread.”

Refael’s family fled Iran when she was 7 because of religious persecu-

tion. Born a few years after the 1979 Islamic Revolution, she was raised in an era when hijabs were mandatory and people had to adhere, she said, to the “anti-American and antisemitic policies of the state.”

Refael has never been able to return. Like other Iranian Americans, she said she feels “a sense of guilt” being physically far from the crisis in her homeland — watching with bountiful internet and electricity, living among Americans who pay little attention to what is happening on the streets of Iran.

The demonstrations, which began Dec. 28, were sparked by a catastrophic crash of Iran’s currency, the rial. They have since spread to all of the country’s 31 provinces, with protesters challenging the rule of 86-year-old Supreme Leader Ayatollah [See Iran, A6]

Family says protester blinded at rally

Hit with a nonlethal round, the anti-ICE demonstrator lost use of one eye, they say.

By Ruben Vives and Itzel Luna

A young protester narrowly avoided being killed but was left permanently blind in one eye after a Department of Homeland Security agent fired a nonlethal round at close range during a Santa Ana protest last week, according to family of the victim.

Jeri Rees said her 21-year-

old nephew, Kaden Rummeler, underwent six hours of surgery and that doctors found shards of plastic, glass and metal embedded in his eyes and around his face, including a metal piece lodged 7 millimeters from a carotid artery.

“That could have cost him his life,” Rees said.

“But now, for the next six weeks, he can’t sneeze or cough because it could do a lot of damage.”

She said doctors did not want to remove the shrapnel near the artery out of fear that it could kill him. She said her nephew also suffered a fractured skull around his eyes and nose

and that doctors said he had permanently lost the vision in his left eye. She said the Homeland Security agent was a few feet from her nephew when he fired the weapon.

Several videos of Friday’s incident were shared on social media. One video shows demonstrators, who were protesting the fatal shooting in Minnesota of Renee Good, throwing orange safety cones at the agents, who were standing guard outside the Santa Ana federal building.

The video cuts to three agents approaching the group before one agent tries to take a young person into

custody, prompting at least three demonstrators to try to intervene. The person taken into custody was identified by friends as Skye Jones.

In the video, at least one agent appears to fire nonlethal rounds at the crowd, hitting one woman in the leg before aiming and striking Rummeler’s face.

The video shows Rummeler dropping to the ground after being shot, holding his face as the crowd retreats. The same agent then drags him by the hood of his jacket; he appears to be choking, grasping at the jacket binding his neck as blood pours [See Protester, A6]

Dinner for \$1,500? People are lining up

Renowned restaurant Noma is planning an L.A. pop-up. Many want that reservation.

By Laurie Ochoa

Ever since chef René Redzepi announced that he is coming to Los Angeles to create a pop-up version of Noma, the Copenhagen restaurant named No. 1 in the world five times, food lovers across the world have reached out to ask how they can get reservations, even though the dates, location and cost were unknown.

On Monday morning Noma released an Instagram post with details about its Los Angeles residency, which will begin March 11 and run through June 20. By nightfall, more than 26,000 people had signed up for the chance to make a reservation at the pop-up by attaching the phrase “LA26” to the post.

Only a fraction of those people will get a reservation.

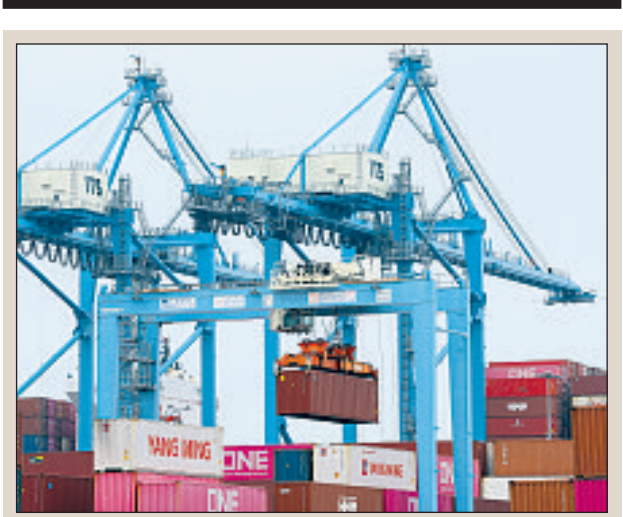
Just 42 guests will be served at each seating, four days a week, at a location in Silver Lake that will be revealed to those with a confirmed reservation (to protect the residential neighborhood surrounding the site).

And the cost? At \$1,500, it’s less than a Super Bowl ticket, which is expected to cost a minimum of \$4,000, but more than almost every other restaurant in Los Angeles.

“I just sent \$1,500 to my local food bank,” wrote one commenter on The Times’ website. “Thanks for reminding all of us what’s really important these days.”

Redzepi, who doesn’t expect to make a profit on his Los Angeles ventures — he’s aiming only to break even — would likely agree with that sentiment. He says he didn’t come to Los Angeles solely to feed the elite.

[See Noma, A8]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

AIMING FOR GROWTH

After a record year when it comes to handling cargo containers, the Port of Long Beach hopes to double the amount by 2050. **BUSINESS, A9**

Clintons refuse to testify in probe

They call a House committee’s inquiry into sex offender Jeffrey Epstein “legally invalid.” **NATION, A4**

Weather

Very warm. L.A. Basin: 86/56. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Cartoonist of ‘Dilbert’ dies

Scott Adams had become a controversial figure in recent years. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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City delays release of firefighters’ testimony

Attorneys block depositions of crews called to blaze that reignited in Palisades.

By Jenny Jarvie and Alene Tchekmedyian

Attorneys for the city of Los Angeles moved this week to block the release of long-awaited depositions of firefighters that could provide a deeper understanding of their decisions and actions in the days leading up to the deadly Palisades fire.

The attorneys representing the city in a lawsuit brought by Palisades fire victims invoked a general protective order the parties agreed to in June, which allows any side to designate all or part of any testimony in the case as confidential for up to 30 days. The parties are supposed to meet during that period to work out which parts should stay confidential, with any disagree-

ments resolved by the judge.

The Los Angeles Fire Department has faced growing scrutiny of its handling of the New Year’s Eve Lachman fire ever since federal officials revealed that its embers rekindled into the Jan. 7, 2025, Palisades blaze that killed 12 people and destroyed thousands of homes.

In October, The Times reported that an LAFD battalion chief ordered firefighters to pick up their hoses from the Lachman burn scar Jan. 2, even though crews warned that the ground was still smoldering. The LAFD also did not use thermal imaging technology to detect underground hot spots.

[See Testimony, A8]

LAFD to move on from fire report

Chief says he won’t look into who ordered edits to water down after-action study. **CALIFORNIA, B1**